

The Leap of Faith: Kierkegaard on Anxiety, Despair, and Authentic Choice

An original lesson plan inspired by **Jon B. Stewart's** *Søren Kierkegaard: A Free Online Course* (Open Culture). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Open Culture or Jon B. Stewart. Explore the original course: <https://www.openculture.com/2017/04/soren-kierkegaard-a-free-online-course.html>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12

DURATION

55 minutes

TOPICS

Existentialism

“Kierkegaard argues we are “condemned” to make life-defining choices without any rational guarantee that we’re choosing correctly — is honestly embracing this anxiety the only way to live authentically?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Kierkegaard's three stages of existence: the aesthetic, the ethical, and the religious.
- Analyze the biblical story of Abraham and Isaac, as read in *Fear and Trembling*, as a test case for what Kierkegaard calls the “teleological suspension of the ethical.”
- Connect Kierkegaard's concepts of anxiety and despair to a modern decision-making scenario with no clear rational answer.

Materials Needed

- Short excerpt handout summarizing Kierkegaard's three stages (aesthetic, ethical, religious) with 1–2 illustrative lines each
- Short excerpt or summary of the Abraham/Isaac discussion from *Fear and Trembling*
- Index cards for the hook activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: A Choice With No Rulebook

8 min

Present a realistic scenario with no clear rationally “correct” answer (for example: choosing between two significantly different colleges, or between staying in a hometown to support family versus leaving for an opportunity elsewhere). Ask students, individually, to write down how they would decide and whether they think there’s a single objectively right answer. Collect a few responses — most will admit no calculation fully settles it.

Direct Instruction: The Three Stages

15 min

Introduce Kierkegaard's three stages of existence: the aesthetic stage (living for immediate pleasure, novelty, and avoiding boredom, which Kierkegaard argues ultimately leads to despair); the ethical stage (committing to universal moral duties and a coherent, responsible life); and the religious stage (a further step requiring a "leap of faith" that goes beyond what universal ethical reasoning alone can justify). Note that Kierkegaard presents these through pseudonymous authors rather than speaking directly, a deliberate strategy to provoke the reader's own engagement rather than hand over a doctrine.

Text Analysis: Abraham and Isaac

17 min

In small groups, students read the excerpt on Abraham's binding of Isaac. According to ordinary ethical reasoning, killing one's own child is monstrous; yet Kierkegaard reads Abraham's willingness to obey God's command as an act of faith that suspends — for Abraham alone, and only in that moment — the universal ethical duty not to kill. Groups should discuss: what would the "ethical stage" say Abraham should do? What does Kierkegaard think the "religious stage" asks of him instead? Is Abraham a hero of faith, or is he simply wrong?

Socratic Discussion

12 min

Bring the class back together to discuss the case. Push on the discomfort: if religious duty really can override ethical duty in extreme cases, how would anyone ever distinguish genuine faith from delusion or dangerous fanaticism? Kierkegaard does not offer an easy answer — use this tension to connect back to the day's opening scenario: like Abraham, we sometimes face choices no external rulebook can settle for us.

Closure

3 min

Ask students to revisit their index card from the hook. Would Kierkegaard say their decision-making approach reflects the aesthetic, ethical, or religious stage? Collect a few responses to close.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is Kierkegaard right that no external authority — not reason, not universal ethical rules — can make our most important choices for us?
- 2 How, if at all, could someone tell the difference between a genuine "leap of faith" and simply making an unjustified or dangerous decision?
- 3 Kierkegaard argues that anxiety is the natural companion of freedom — does recognizing your own freedom to choose actually feel anxiety-inducing to you, or comforting?
- 4 Is living permanently in the "aesthetic stage" (pursuing novelty and pleasure without deeper commitment) really doomed to despair, as Kierkegaard claims, or can it be a stable way to live?

Assessment

Students write a short response explaining, in their own words, why the Abraham and Isaac story counts as a "teleological suspension of the ethical" for Kierkegaard, and giving their own view on whether Kierkegaard is right that some choices genuinely can't be settled by universal ethical rules.



Extension Activity

Have students identify a real decision (personal, historical, or fictional) that seems to resist a clean rational solution, and write a short analysis of it using Kierkegaard's three stages and his concepts of anxiety and despair.

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